DEVO #0

"IN THE SWEAT OF THY FACE SHALT THOU EAT BREAD, TILL THOU RETURN UNTO THE GROUND; FOR OUT OF IT WAST THOU TAKEN: FOR DUST THOU ART, AND UNTO DUST SHALT THOU RETURN" (GENESIS 3:19).

THERE IS NO GREATER SUMMARY OF THE HUMAN CONDITION THAN THE PUNISHMENT GIVEN TO THE FIRST HUMANS DIRECTLY SUCCEEDING THE ORIGINAL SIN IN THE THIRD CHAPTER OF GENESIS. THIS DEPRESSING REALITY OF LIFE SETS THE SCENE FOR EPISODE 0. THE WORLD HAS NOTHING TO OFFER. AS ADAM WAS BORN OF THE DIRT, SO HE WILL RETURN. IN THE END, HE HAS NO ABILITY TO GAIN ANYTHING, EXCEPT THROUGH FAITH AND OBEDIENCE IN HIS CREATOR.

THE FIRST SCENE OPENS WITH YANAGI (LIT. "WILLOW") BEING BROUGHT UP AS "THE SEED OF THE LAND" LIKE "A WILLOW TREE" (EZEKIEL 17:5), ECHOING EZEKIEL'S PROPHECY OF KING ZEDEKIAH, WHOM BABYLON PLANTED IN STABILITY, ONLY FOR HIM TO RUIN IT THROUGH PRIDE AND REBELLION. WILL YANAGI DO THE SAME?

IT IS CERTAINLY THE PRAYER OF HER NEWFOUND COMPANION THAT SHE SHOULD NOT. THE FIERY ROOT VEGETABLE IMMEDIATELY CONSOLES HER WITH THE PROMISE THAT "THROUGH DEATH COMES LIFE," INDICATING, AS THE APOSTLE JOHN NOTES, THAT SHE WILL BE REVIVED FROM HER CURRENT STATE OF DEATH AND WILL BE "PASSED FROM DEATH UNTO LIFE" (JOHN 5:24).

FIREBEET FOLLOWS WITH AN APPEAL TO YANAGI TO FOLLOW HIM INTO A "LAND OF DARKNESS" AND A COMMAND TO "NOT BE AFRAID." HERE, A DUO OF PROMISES FROM THE PROPHET ISAIAH ARE EVOKED. FIRST, THAT GOD "WILL MAKE DARKNESS LIGHT" (ISAIAH 42:16). AND SECOND, THAT GOD "WILL STRENGTHEN... HELP... [AND] UPHOLD THEE WITH THE RIGHT HAND OF [HIS] RIGHTEOUSNESS" (ISAIAH 41:10).

HERE, THE TONE CHANGES. THE INTRODUCTION OF THE EIGHT-LEGGED AUTOCRAT AND HIS MINIONS REPRESENTS "THE RULERS OF THE DARKNESS OF THIS WORLD" (EPHESIANS 6:12), WHOM WE AS CHRISTIANS ARE COMMANDED TO FIGHT.

TO WAGE WAR ON THE EVIL OF THE WORLD IS THE SINGULAR, HOLY MOTIVATION OF YANAGI'S GUIDE. LIKE THE WEEPING PROPHET, JEREMIAH, WHO FACED SEVERE

PERSECUTION IN JUDAH FOR PROPHESYING OF THEIR COMING EXILE, FIREBEET IS COMPELLED TO LEAD THE OCCUPANTS OF TURNSOIL TO SALVATION THROUGH HIS ABILITY TO PROCLAIM TRUTH. FOR IN THE YEARS PRECEDING JUDAH'S EXILE, JEREMIAH TEARFULLY PLEADED WITH THE PEOPLE OF JUDAH OVER A SPAN OF DECADES, FACING MOMENTS OF INTENSE SPIRITUAL EXHAUSTION WHERE HE RESOLVED TO "NOT MAKE MENTION OF HIM, NOR SPEAK ANY MORE IN HIS NAME" (JEREMIAH 20:9). BUT EVEN THE PHYSICAL, MENTAL, AND SPIRITUAL PERSECUTION HE ENDURED WOULD NOT DETER HIM FROM PROCLAIMING THE LORD'S WORD, WHICH HE DESCRIBED IN VIVID DETAIL AS "A BURNING FIRE SHUT UP IN [HIS] BONES" (JEREMIAH 20:9).

THE METAPHOR OF FIRE APPEARS LATER IN THE SCRIPTURES WHEN JESUS INVOKES IT TO DESCRIBE THE GOSPEL'S QUALITIES OF CONSUMING, TESTING, AND PURIFYING, SAYING, "I AM COME TO SEND FIRE ON THE EARTH; AND WHAT WILL I, IF IT BE ALREADY KINDLED?" (LUKE 12:49). THIS VERSE IS USED AS THE REFERENCE VERSE FOR FIREBEET'S "HOLY FIRE" CARD, REINFORCING HIS SINCERE DESIRE TO CONSUME EVIL, TEST THE AUTHENTICITY OF FAITH, AND PURIFY THE TOWN OF TURNSOIL.

THE MENTOR FURTHER EXPOUNDS UPON THE FIRST QUALITY OF "HOLY FIRE" (CONSUMING) BY DEMANDING YANAGI "FOLLOW [HIM]" AND "RAIN HELLFIRE UPON THE HEADS OF THE WICKED," REFLECTING DAVID'S DESCRIPTION OF GOD'S RIGHTEOUS JUDGMENT TO "RAIN SNARES, FIRE AND BRIMSTONE, AND AN HORRIBLE TEMPEST" (PSALM 11:6) UPON HIS ENEMIES. JUST AS DAVID, IN THE MIDST OF BETRAYAL AND CORRUPTION, REFUSED TO FLEE TO THE MOUNTAINS, CHOOSING RATHER TO TRUST IN GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY AND PROTECTION, SO DOES FIREBEET INTEND TO APPROACH THE WICKEDNESS OF TURNSOIL.

DESPITE FIREBEET'S ZEAL, YANAGI IS NOT IMMEDIATELY CONVINCED OF THIS AGGRESSIVE APPROACH. THIS LEADS TO HIS FIERY REBUKE OF THE YOUNG GIRL, SIMILAR TO THE PROPHET SAMUEL'S REBUKE OF KING SAUL FOR DEFYING THE LORD'S COMMAND TO COMPLETELY DESTROY THE AMALEKITES—AN ADVERSARY THAT RUTHLESSLY ATTACKED THE ISRAELITES DURING THE EXODUS—DECLARING THAT "REBELLION IS AS THE SIN OF WITCHCRAFT, AND STUBBORNNESS IS AS INIQUITY AND IDOLATRY" (1 SAMUEL 15:23).

BUT RATHER THAN RECIPROCATING ANGER, YANAGI INSTEAD RESPONDS WITH THE HESITANT HUMILITY OF

GIDEON, WHO PLEADED THAT "[HIS] FAMILY [WAS] POOR IN MANASSEH, AND [HE WAS] THE LEAST IN [HIS] FATHER'S HOUSE" (JUDGES 6:15) IN RESPONSE TO THE ANGEL OF THE LORD CALLING HIM TO DELIVER ISRAEL FROM SEVERE OPPRESSION.

AT THIS POINT, FIREBEET ADJUSTS HIS TONE AND APPEALS TO YANAGI'S HUMANITY. EVIDENTLY, HUMAN BEINGS ARE SIGNIFICANT IN THE WORLD OF TURNSOIL, BUT SO ARE THEY IN OUR WORLD. FOR AS THE PSALMIST DECLARES: "WHAT IS MAN, THAT THOU ART MINDFUL OF HIM? AND THE SON OF MAN, THAT THOU VISITEST HIM? FOR THOU HAST MADE HIM A LITTLE LOWER THAN THE ANGELS, AND HAST CROWNED HIM WITH GLORY AND HONOUR" (PSALM 8:4-5).

IN LIGHT OF THESE TRUTHS—SPIRITUAL RENEWAL, DIVINE ILLUMINATION, SUSTAINING STRENGTH, AND INHERENT SIGNIFICANCE—YANAGI SHOULD "BE NOT AFRAID" (JOSHUA 1:9).

FIREBEET'S FINAL APPEAL IS AIMED DIRECTLY AT AN EARLY-EMERGING CHARACTER TRAIT OF YANAGI: COMPASSION. HE DIRECTS HER TO "LOOK INTO [HIS] FIRE," AND WHAT SHE SEES IS THE PAIN, DEATH, AND GROANINGS OF THE RESIDENTS OF TURNSOIL. HERE ON EARTH, "THE SPIRIT ALSO HELPETH OUR

INFIRMITIES: FOR WE KNOW NOT WHAT WE SHOULD PRAY FOR AS WE OUGHT: BUT THE SPIRIT ITSELF MAKETH INTERCESSION FOR US WITH GROANINGS WHICH CANNOT BE UTTERED" (ROMANS 8:26). BUT WHO WILL INTERCEDE FOR THE OPPRESSED CITIZENS OF TURNSOIL? AND WHO WILL HEAR AND TRANSLATE THEIR GROANINGS?

WHEN FACED WITH THE THREAT OF DEATH, DAVID MAINTAINED FAITH, WRITING: "THE RIGHTEOUS CRY, AND THE LORD HEARETH, AND DELIVERETH THEM OUT OF ALL THEIR TROUBLES" (PSALM 34:17). BUT WHO WILL HEAR THE OPPRESSED CITIZENS OF TURNSOIL? AND WHO WILL DELIVER THEM?

THE DISPLAY OF TURNSOIL'S TURMOIL THROUGH FIREBEET'S CRACKLING FLAMES IS BROUGHT TO A CLOSE WITH ONE FINAL REMINDER THAT "THE LIGHT SHINETH IN DARKNESS" (JOHN 1:5).

HERE, THE CHANGE IN YANAGI'S DISPOSITION IS EVIDENT. JUST AS JOB WAS TRANSFORMED FROM MERELY HEARING ABOUT GOD TO DECLARING, "MINE EYE SEETH THEE" (JOB 42:5) WHEN GOD ANSWERED HIM FROM THE WHIRLWIND, SO YANAGI HAS SEEN A VISION OF TURNSOIL'S SUFFERING AND AGREES TO AID FIREBEET, BUT ONLY UNDER ONE CONDITION: THAT

SHE BE RETURNED "BACK TO LIFE AND AWAY FROM THIS OH-SO DREADED PLACE."

FIREBEET AGREES TO HER CONDITION AND REITERATES ONCE MORE THAT SHE "MAY SEE LIFE AGAIN," INSISTING THAT SHE MUST FIRST "[DESCEND] TO DEATH AND [DEFEAT] EVIL," JUST AS CHRIST PROPHESIED OF HIS OWN DEATH: "EXCEPT A CORN OF WHEAT FALL INTO THE GROUND AND DIE, IT ABIDETH ALONE: BUT IF IT DIE, IT BRINGETH FORTH MUCH FRUIT" (JOHN 12:24). BUT WHO WILL GRANT SALVATION TO THE TOWN OF TURNSOIL?